



Sell On or Off?

Want to sell your old phone to upgrade to the new one? Here's a few tips.
<http://dgit.in/IUpgrade>

Agent 001

GPU Required

Hi! I've been reading your magazine for a long time now, but this is the first time that I'm writing in. The reason being that I want to upgrade my one year old PC so that I can play most current generation games easily. At the time of buying my PC, I didn't purchase a new graphics card because of budget constraints and used the ageing Nvidia 9600GT from my old system. But now, I've finally decided to invest in a new graphics card and my budget for the same is around the ₹25,000 mark. Please recommend a good card for the price. Here are my PC specifications:

- Processor: Intel Core i5 4460
- Motherboard: Asrock Z97 Extreme 3
- RAM: G.Skill Sniper 8GB (4GB x 2 sticks)
- Graphics Card: Nvidia 9600GT
- Power Supply: Cooler Master V700

– Avinash Kadam

A Hi Avinash. It looks like you have a pretty decent system at your disposal with the exception of that old 9600GT. The budget that you've set for a new graphics card will get you a really good card. We'd recommend going and getting the GTX 970 from the likes of ASUS or ZOTAC. The ZOTAC GTX 970 ZT-90101-10P will set you back for ₹27,000, which is a decent GPU that'll let you run current gen games with ease. You can try and get the GTX 970 for even cheaper if you have someone living in the US who can get it for you. Two members of Team Digit have done the same and got GTX 970s by EVGA for around 20K and you can try doing the same. All the best.

Mini-ITX case wanted

Hi Agent 001! I'm writing to you because I'm in need of a new Mini-ITX cabinet for a PC that I had built quite recently. Currently I've installed the components into an old mid-tower iBall case but I want to switch them over to a much smaller Mini-ITX case that'll not only save some space for me but also looks good enough to be kept in my office. The components that I have are the Intel Core i3 4340 on a Gigabyte GA-H97N-WIFI motherboard coupled with 8GB of RAM from Kingston and a Sapphire R7 265 GPU. Please suggest a few different Mini-ITX cases that are capable of supporting my existing components. I'm willing to pay not more than ₹4000 for it.

– Deepak Singh

A Since you're looking for a Mini-ITX case, you have a few good options to choose from. One important point to note here is that since you have a standard sized GPU that takes up two expansion slots, the case that you select should have at least two PCIe expansion slots. You can select from among these cases:

1. Antec ISK600: ₹4,500
2. Cooler Master Elite 130: ₹4,250
3. Corsair Obsidian 250D: ₹6,000

Both Antec and the Cooler Master options are good for a Mini-ITX build and can house your current components. In case you might want to go overboard with your budget, the case from Corsair's Obsidian series might appeal to you. **d**

GAME ART CAN GET TRICKY

Read on for some easy-to-follow methods for the artistically inclined.

Long before the Game Art course ran its first semester, the gaming campus was home only and only to students of game design. These were professionals well-versed in their own crafts before applying for an education in design. Programmers were in high demand (at 30% of total population between 6 teams), and artists were a rarer resource (15%) – only because they hailed from either discipline. To that end, the artists shared a few processes of their own to make visual content creation easier, while still maintaining the feel of a high-budget production:

1. Draw maps when creating assets for environments
2. Flesh out key characteristics of your objects before animating them
3. Give your characters the most attention to detail - players remember and spend time interacting with them
4. Pick your colours carefully - visit <http://color.adobe.com>
5. Get ready to push yourself
6. Give your characters personality - any tiny addition you make, be it a pouch on the character's belt or a scar on the face, tells you that much more about who the character is
7. Never lose track of your asset sizes
8. Accentuate your environment with extra detail
9. Try to blend your interface with your game world – Halo and Dead Space do it well, by showing ammo on the rifle itself and health on the character's back respectively
10. Give yourself time to breathe

The Game Art course began in 2013, bringing its own insights into art created specifically for games. Students in this discipline are taught the best practices in the industry, and hence enable others (who themselves aren't artists) to follow through with their artistic vision even better:

1. Concept art is your best vision of the project during pre-production
2. Always iterate; start with low-detail assets to use as wireframes
3. View your environments without textures for perfect scale
4. Keep watching others; you never know what you may learn!
5. Make your player-controlled character perfect
6. Know your limitations (file-size or polygon-count)
7. Understand and use the right tools
8. Always polish!
9. Never rush the process and
10. Take a break when you know you need one.

Novice or professional, these everyday practices make a huge difference, especially when working on a game that players the world over are going to have access to. So if you know an artist, are an artist or are just another curious developer from a different discipline trying to get some art ready: we hope this has been especially helpful to you.

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